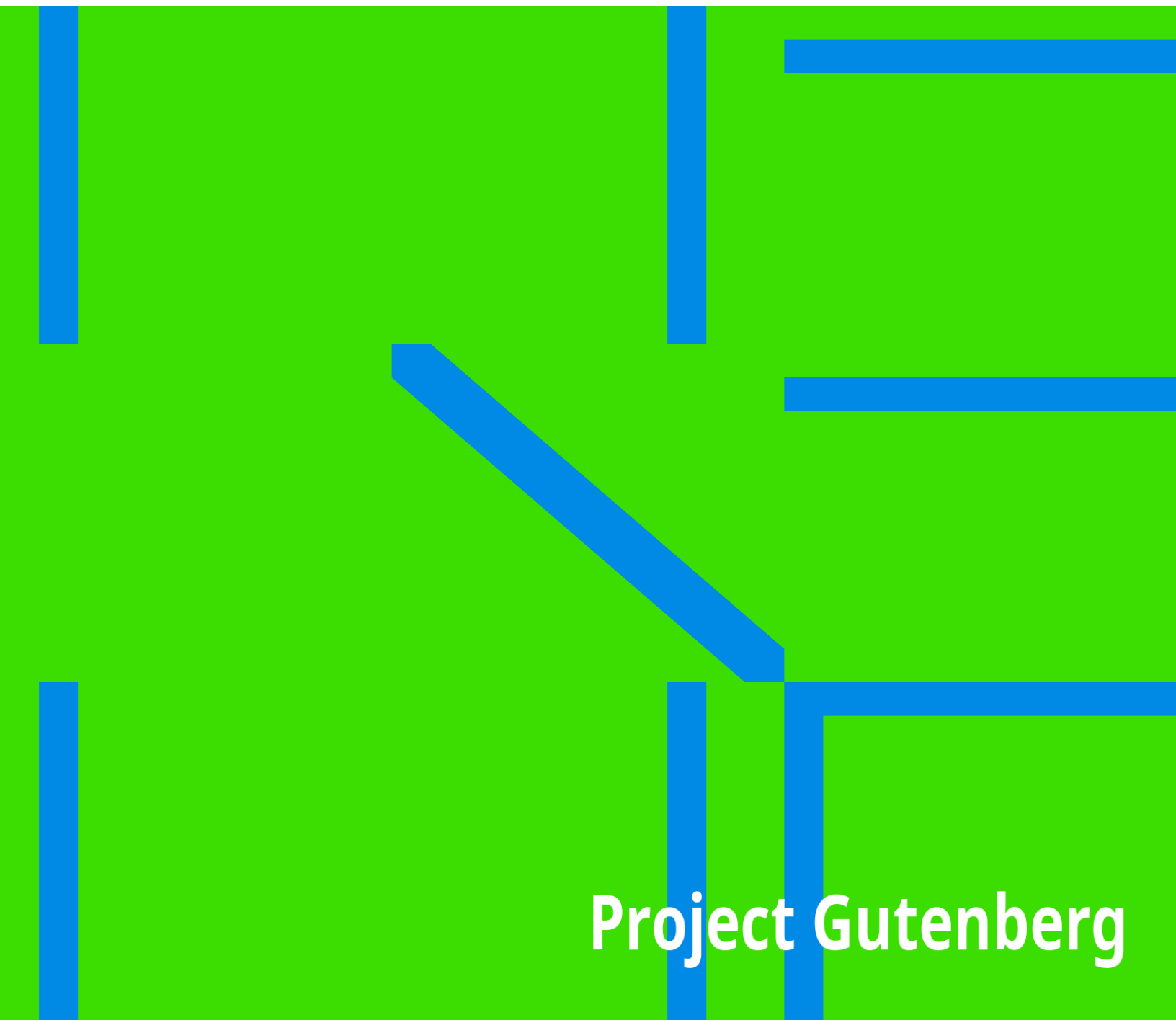


The Methodist

a poem

Evan Lloyd

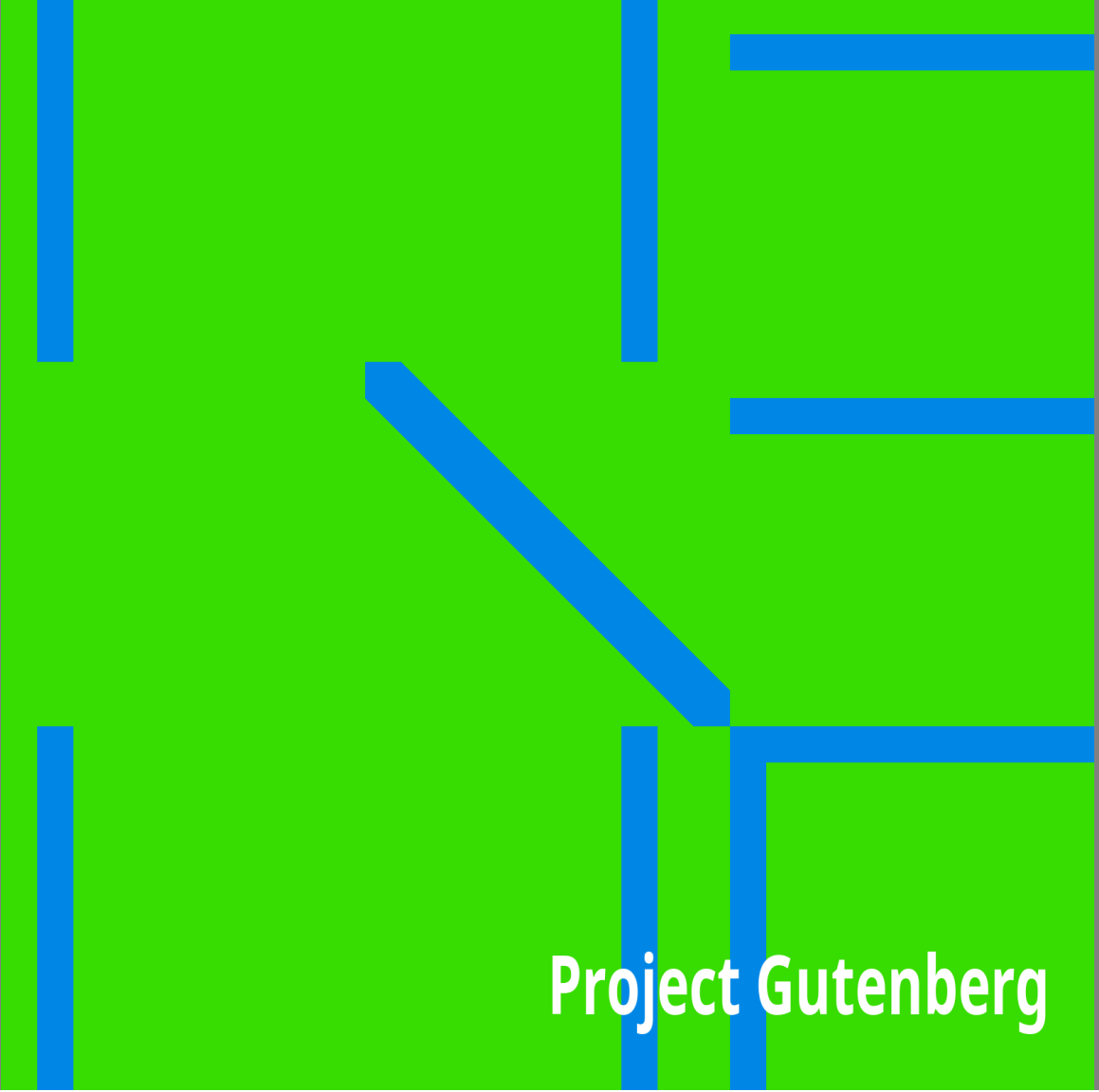
An abstract geometric design featuring several thick blue lines of varying lengths and orientations (vertical, horizontal, and diagonal) set against a solid green background. The lines are arranged in a way that suggests a stylized architectural or structural framework.

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The Methodist

a poem

Evan Lloyd

An abstract geometric design featuring a large green rectangular area. Overlaid on this green area are several blue lines of varying thicknesses. These lines form a series of interconnected shapes, including vertical bars, horizontal bars, and a prominent diagonal line that crosses the lower half of the green area. The lines appear to be part of a larger, possibly architectural or structural, plan or map.

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THE AUGUSTAN REPRINT SOCIETY

EVAN LLOYD

THE METHODIST.

A POEM.

(1766)

Introduction by

RAYMOND BENTMAN

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INTRODUCTION

Evan Lloyd's works consist chiefly of four satires written in 1766 and 1767,^[1] all of which are now little-known. What little notice he receives today results from his friendship with John Wilkes and David Garrick and from one satire, *The Methodist*, which is usually included in surveys of anti-Methodist literature.^[2] For the most part, his obscurity is deserved. In *The Methodist*, however, he participates in a short-lived revolt against the tyranny of Augustan satire and shows considerable evidence of a talent that might have created a new style for formal verse satire.

The seventeen-sixties were a difficult period for satire. The struggle between Crown and Parliament, the new industrial and agricultural methods, the workers' demands for higher pay, the new rural and urban poor, the growth of the Empire, the deteriorating relations with the American colonies, the increasing influence of the ideas of the Enlightenment, the popularity of democratic ideas, the Wilkes controversy, the growth of Methodism, the growth of the novel, the interest in the gothic and the picturesque and in chinoiserie, sentimentality, enthusiasm—all these activities made England a highly volatile country. Some changes were truly dynamic, others just fads. But to someone living in the period, who dared to look around him, the complexity of the present and the uncertainty of the future must have seemed enormous.

To a satirist, such complexity makes art difficult. Satire usually deals with every-day realities, to which it applies simple moral ideals. The Augustan satiric alternative—returning to older beliefs in religion, government, philosophy, art—and the stylistic expression of such beliefs—formal verse satire and epistle, mock-poem, heroic or Hudibrastic couplet, diction of polite conversation, ironic metaphysical conceits, fantastic fictional situations—become irrelevant to the satirist writing when the past seems lost. In his later works, Pope took Augustan satire about as far as it could go. *The Epilogue to the Satires*

becomes an epilogue to all Augustan satire and the conclusion of *The New Dunciad* declares the death of its own tradition. There is a sense now that England and the world have reached the point of no return. The satirist of the seventeen-sixties who repeats the ideas and styles of Butler, Dryden, Swift, Gay, and Pope seems not only imitative but out-of-touch with the world around him.

But such difficulties can provide the impetus for new forms and for original styles. And in the seventeen-sixties the writers of formal satire show signs of responding to the challenge. Christopher Anstey, Charles Churchill, Robert Lloyd, and Evan Lloyd seem, during this decade, to be developing their considerable facilities with satiric technique toward the creation of new styles. Anstey's *New Bath Guide* has a combination of epistolary fiction, realism, use of naive observers, changing points of view, sweeping view of the social scene, great range of subjects, rollicking verse forms, and tone of detached amusement which suggests a satirist who, while still largely derivative, had the talent to create new techniques. Churchill and Robert Lloyd are explicit in their wish to break from Augustan style. Churchill argues that it was "a sin 'gainst Pleasure, to design / A plan, to methodize each thought, each line / Highly to finish." He claims to write "When the mad fit comes on" and praises poetry written "Wild without art, and yet with pleasure wild" (*Gotham* [1764], II, 167-169, 172, 212). His satire—with its deliberate, irreverent, "Byronic" run-on lines, fanciful digressions, playful indifference to formal structure, impulsively involuted syntax, long, wandering sentences—seems to move, as does Robert Lloyd's satire (at a somewhat slower pace), toward a genuinely new style. In being chatty, fluid, iconoclastic, spontaneous-sounding, self-revealing, his satire might eventually prove capable of dealing with the problems that the Augustan satirists had predicted but did not have to deal with so directly. But both Churchill and Robert Lloyd died before they could develop their styles to the point that they had a new, timely statement to make. Anstey failed to develop beyond the *New Bath Guide*, and his influence proved to be more important on the novel than on verse satire.

Evan Lloyd's first satire, *The Powers of the Pen*, is a clever but ordinary satire on good and bad writing. It has some historical interest

as an example of the early influence of Rousseau in England, of part of the attack on Samuel Johnson for his adverse criticism of Shakespeare, of the influence of Churchill (Lloyd declared himself a disciple), and of the expression of the fashionable interest in artlessness which was influenced as much by Joseph Warton as by Rousseau. In a “quill shop” the narrator discovers magic pens which write like various authors. The one whose “Mate was purchas’d by Rousseau” can:

Teach the Passions how to grow
With native Vigour; unconfined
By those vile Shackles, which the Mind
Wears in the *School of Art*....
Yet will no *Heresies* admit,
To gratify the *Pride of Wit* (p. 30).

He advances these critical dicta elsewhere in this satire, condemning Johnson because he tries “Nature” by “*Critic-law*” (p. 21). With fashionable Rousseauistic ideas he praises:

The *Muse*, who never lov’d the Town,
Ne’er flaunted in brocaded Gown;
Pleas’d thro’ the hawthorn’d Vale to roam,
Or sing her artless Strain at Home,
Bred in plain Nature’s simple Rules,
Far from the Foppery of Schools (p. 36).

Evan Lloyd, Robert Lloyd, and Churchill, starting from somewhat different philosophic principles, all arrive at similar positions.

The Curate, his second satire, is largely autobiographical. It shows, as does *The Powers of the Pen*, some clever turns of phrases, pithy expressions, and amusing images. It also contains incisive criticism of corruption in the Church, of declining respect for Christianity, and, what seems to Lloyd almost the same thing, of a collapsing class structure. The Church wardens, “uncivil and unbred! / Unlick’d, untaught, un-all-things—but unfed!” are “but sweepers of the pews, / The *Scullions of the Church*, they dare abuse, / And rudely treat their betters” (pp. 16-17). They show a lack of proper respect both for class-structure and Christianity:

Servant to Christ! and what is that to me?
I keep a servant too, as well as He (p. 17).

But *The Curate* frequently descends to a whine. The curate is morally above reproach while those above him are arrogant and those below him are disrespectful.

The most serious problem with *The Curate*, however, is the same as the problem with all of Lloyd's satires except *The Methodist*, and the same as the problem with almost all satires between Pope and Burns or Blake. The satirist seems unwilling to probe, to find out what are the political, ethical, psychological, or aesthetic forces that cause the problems which the satirist condemns, and to recommend what can be done to change these forces. If the satirist notes any pattern at all, it is one of ineffective, unmoving abstraction and generality.

One explanation for this deliberate avoidance of more profound issues is not hard to find. An astonishing number of satires of this period contain a large proportion of lines devoted to describing how wonderful everything is. The widespread conviction that whatever is, in the England of the late eighteenth century, is right, may have resulted from the influence of *An Essay on Man*. Or the *Essay* may have been popular because it expressed ideas already in general acceptance. But whatever the explanation is, the catch-phrases extracted from Pope's most popular work become the touchstones of post-Augustan satire.

The problem that the satirist faced in the sixties was, then, formidable. The country was in upheaval but the conventions demanded that the satirist say everything was nearly perfect. As a result, satire tended toward personal whines, like *The Curate*, toward attacking tiresomely obvious objects, like the superficial chit-chat of Lloyd's *Conversation*, toward trivial quarrels, like Churchill's *Rosciad*, toward broadly unimpeachable morals, like Johnson's *The Vanity of Human Wishes*. It is understandable that many writers, such as Joseph Warton and Christopher Smart, abandoned satire for various kinds of enthusiasm.

Methodism lent itself to such satire. Methodists could be described as unfortunate aberrants from an essentially good world, typical of those

bothersome fanatics and deviants at the fringe of society who keep this world from being perfect. They were also logical heirs to the satire once visited upon Dissenters but which diminished when Dissenters became more restrained in their style of worship. (The Preface to one anti-Methodist satire even takes pains to exclude “rational Dissenters” from its target.) Many Methodists were followers of Calvin. These Methodists brought out the old antagonisms against the Calvinist doctrine of Election (or the popular version of it), directed against its severity, its apparent encouragement of pride, and its antinomian implications. The mass displays of emotion at Methodist meetings would be distasteful to many people in most periods and probably were especially so in an age in which rational behavior was particularly valued. And there were those people who believed that Methodism, in spite of Wesley’s arguments to the contrary, led good members of the Church of England astray and threatened religious stability.

Yet all these causes do not explain the harshness of anti-Methodist satire. No other subject during this period received such severe condemnation. Wesley and Whitefield were accused of seducing their female converts, of fleecing all their converts of money, of making trouble solely out of envy or pride. Evan Lloyd is not so harsh nor so implacably bigoted about any other subject as he is about Methodism. He was an intimate friend of John Wilkes, the least bigoted of men. Also, there are essential differences between the Dissenters of the Restoration and the Methodists of the late eighteenth century that would seem to lessen the antagonism toward the Methodists. To the satirists of the Restoration, Dissenters were reminders of civil war, regicide, the chaos that religious division could bring. Now the only threat of religious war or major civil disturbance had come from the Jacobites, and even that threat was safely in the past. It is notable that Swift, Pope, and Gay tended to satirize Dissenters within the context of larger problems. The assault on Methodists, then, is actually not a continuation of anti-Dissenter satire but something new. Hence the whole movement of anti-Methodist satire in the sixties and seventies has an untypically violent tone which cannot be explained solely in

terms of satiric trends or religious attitudes. The explanation lies, I think, partly in the social, political, and economic background.

The Methodist movement was perhaps the most dramatic symptom (or at least the symptom hardest to ignore) of the changes taking place in England. The Methodist open-air services were needed because new industrial areas had sprung up where there were no churches, and lay preachers were necessary because of population shifts but also because of the increase in population made possible by new agricultural and manufacturing methods. The practice of taking lay preachers from many social classes had obvious democratic implications. Wesley, in spite of his political conservatism, challenged a number of widely-held, complacent aphorisms, such as the belief that people are “poor only because they are idle.”^[3] The mass emotionalism of the evangelical meetings were reminders that man was not so rational as certain popular ideas tried to make him. Wesley’s insistence (with irritatingly good evidence) that he did no more than adhere to the true doctrine of the Church of England strongly suggested that the Church of England had strayed somewhere. (It is rather interestingly paralleled by Wilkes’s insistence that he only wanted to return to the Declaration of Rights, a reminder that the government had also strayed.) And Methodism, by its very existence and popularity, posed the question of whether the Church of England, in its traditional form, was capable of dealing with problems created by social and economic changes.

These social, economic, and political issues are touched upon by a number of the anti-Methodist satirists. Most of these satirists, however, are contented simply to complain about the lower class tone of the Methodist movement, to note generally, as Dryden and Swift had noted before, that Protestantism contained the seeds of mob rule. The anonymous author of *The Saints* fears “Their frantic pray’r [is] a mere *Decoy for Mob*” (p. 4) and the author^[4] of *The Methodist and Mimic* claims that Whitefield’s preaching sends “the Brainless Mob a gadding” (p. 15). Evan Lloyd is the one anti-Methodist satirist who explores the larger implications.

Lloyd constructs his satire around the theme of general corruption, that nothing is so virtuous that it cannot be spoiled either by man’s

weakness or by time. The theme is common in the period and could have become banal, except that Lloyd applies it to the corruption of the Church and its manifestations in daily life, giving it an immediate, lively reference. The Methodist practice of lay preachers, for example, Lloyd treats as an instance of the collapse of the class system:

Each vulgar Trade, each sweaty Brow
Is search'd...
Hence ev'ry Blockhead, Knave, and Dunce,
Start into Preachers all at once (p. 29).

Lloyd combines the language of theology, government, and civil order to suggest a connection between recent riots, the excesses of the Earl of Bute, the Protestant belief that religious concepts are easily understood by all social classes, democracy, the emotional displays of Methodism, and lay preachers:

Hence Ignorance of ev'ry size,
Of ev'ry shape Wit can devise,
Altho' so dull it hardly knows, ...
When it is Day, or when 'tis Night,
Shall yet pretend to keep the Key
Of God's dark Secrets, and display
His *hidden Mysteries*, as free
As if *God's privy Council* He,
Shall to his Presence rush, and dare
To raise a *pious Riot* there (pp. 29-30).

Lloyd presents an essentially disorderly world in which chaos spreads almost inevitably, in which riots, corrupt ministers, arrogant fools, disrespectful lower classes, giddy middle classes, and lascivious upper classes are barely kept in check by a system of social class, government, and church. Now, with the checks withdrawn, lawyers and physicians spread their own disorder even further as they:

Quit their beloved wrangling *Hall*,
More loudly in a *Church* to bawl: ...
And full as fervent, on their Knees,
For *Heav'n* they pray, as once for *Fees*; ...

The *Physic-Tribe* their Art resign,
And lose the *Quack* in the *Divine*; ...
Of a *New-birth* they prate, and prate
While *Midwifry* is out of Date (pp. 30-31).

He combines the language of tradesmen with the language of mythology and theology to suggest, rather wittily and effectively, that disorder can be commonplace and cosmic simultaneously:

The *Bricklay'r* throws his *Trowel* by,
And now *builds Mansions in the Sky*; ...
The *Waterman* forgets his *Wherry*,
And opens a *celestial Ferry*; ...
The *Fishermen* no longer set
For *Fish* the *Meshes* of their *Net*,
But catch, like *Peter, Men of Sin*,
For *catching* is to *take them in* (pp. 32-34).

This spreading confusion is, however, not just a passing social problem but one that results from many breasts being “tainted” and many hearts “infected” (p. 34). The corruption is almost universal and results in Wesley (as he actually did) selling “Powders, Draughts, and Pills.” Madan “the springs of Health *unlocks*,/ And by his Preaching cures the *P[ox]*,” (he was Chaplain of Lock Hospital) and Romaine:

Pulls you by *Gravity up-Hill*, ...
By your *bad Deeds* your *Faith* you shew,
'Tis but *believe*, and *up You go* (p. 36).

Lloyd treats the confusion between sexual desire and religious fervor as another aspect of general human depravity, extending the satire beyond the crude accusation of hypocrisy or cynicism. He argues that the confusion is a part of the human condition, allowed to go out of control by a religion that puts passion before reason. The Countess of Huntingdon, “cloy'd with *carnal Bliss*,” longs “to taste how *Spirits* kiss.” In his all-inclusive catalogue of “*Knaves/ That crawl on Earth*” Lloyd includes “*Prudes* that crowd to *Pews*,/ While their *Thoughts* ramble to the *Stews*” (p. 48).

What makes Lloyd interesting, in spite of his many derivative ideas and techniques, is inadvertently pointed out by the *Critical Review*, which complains that “the author outmethodizes even Methodism itself.”^[5] That the brutal tone of *The Methodist* went beyond the license usually permitted the satirists was recognized by Lloyd himself. At the conclusion of the satire he asks God to halt the Methodist movement by getting to its source:

Quench the hot flame, O God, that Burns
And *Piety* to *Phrenzy* turns!

And then, after a few lines, he applies the same terms to himself:

But soft——my *Muse*! thy *Breath* recall——
Turn not *Religion*’s Milk to Gall!
Let not thy *Zeal* within thee nurse
A holy Rage! or *pious Curse!*
Far other is the *heav’nly Plan*,
Which the *Redeemer* gave to Man (pp. 52-53).

The satirist, as Robert C. Elliott points out, has always, in art, satirized himself.^[6] But there is here as throughout this satire, some attempt to develop a style which will express the belief that the world will always be disorderly and that the disorder stems from man’s “Zeal within.” This condition of the world can be expressed satirically by a personal, informal satire which recognizes and dramatizes just how universal the corruption is and how commonplace its manifestations have become.

The informal, disorderly syntax, the colloquial diction, the chatty tone, the run-on lines, the conscious roughness of meter and rhyme, may have derived from Churchill, but they become here more relevant than in any of Churchill’s satires. They combine with the intemperate tone and the satirist’s concluding confession, his self-identification with the object of satire, to create a sense of an unheroic satirist, one who does not represent a highly commendable satiric alternative. Satire must now turn its vision from the heroic, the apocalyptic, the broadly philosophical, even from the depraved, and become exceedingly ordinary. It must recognize that there is little hope in going back to

lofty Augustan ideals. For such subjects, it uses the impulsive tone of an over-emotional satirist who is as flawed as the subject he satirizes and still represents the best of a disordered world.

Lloyd had attempted an autobiographical satire in *The Curate*. He failed to create an important satire for a number of reasons, one of which was that he tried to present himself as a high ideal, a belief that he apparently held so weakly that the satire became merely petulant. Lloyd corrected this error in *The Methodist* and now seems, however briefly, to have opened the way to a truly prophetic style of satire.

After *The Methodist* Lloyd wrote *Conversation*, a satire that not only failed to fulfill the promise of *The Methodist* but is more conservative in theme and style than any of his earlier satires.

After that work he produced little. He published an expanded version of *The Power of the Pen* and a dull ode printed in *The Annual Register*. When William Kenrick, in *Love in the Suds*, implied that Garrick was Isaac Bickerstaff's lover, Lloyd defended Garrick in *Epistle to David Garrick*. Kenrick replied with *A Whipping for the Welch Parson*, an ironic Dunciad-Variorum-type editing of Lloyd's *Epistle*, in which he got much the better of Lloyd. Lloyd was no match for Kenrick at this sort of thing. Except for these uninteresting productions and his convivial friendship with Wilkes and Garrick, we hear not much more of Lloyd.

We know so little about his life that we can only speculate why he failed to follow up the promise of *The Methodist*; why, after favorable reviews from the journals^[7] and the flattering friendship of famous men, he was not encouraged to continue a career that was as promising as the early career of many famous satirists. The explanation may lie solely in his personality. Perhaps the moderate success he achieved and the financial rewards it brought were enough for him.

Another explanation is suggested by the conservative ideas and style of *Conversation*, which are more like Pope's than are the ideas and style of any earlier satire of Lloyd's. In this satire he explicitly repudiates his older, freer critical dicta in both theory and practice:

Tho' this be *Form*—yet bend to *Form* we
must,
Fools *with it* please, *without it* Wits disgust
(p. 3).

He uses mostly end-stop couplets, parallel constructions, Augustan diction and similes. Apparently, he began his rejection of his new ideas and style immediately after *The Methodist* and before his 1766-1767 outburst of satire-writing was over.

Lloyd, in writing *The Methodist*, seems to have come as close as any satirist before Blake and the writers of *The Anti-Jacobin* to seeing the problems England and the world were headed toward, to recognizing how genuinely volatile English society was in the middle of the century, and to creating a style which could deal with those problems satirically. It may be that he got some realization that his own long passages in *The Methodist* praising this best of all possible worlds (pp. 16-20) and his invocation to the “heav’nly Plan” at the conclusion made no sense, that they were contradicted by other passages in the same satire, that England and the world were changing with enormous rapidity, and that the satirist would have to create a new style to express the tremendous economic, political, social, and religious problems that were coming into being. It may be that getting such a faint notion he withdrew into artistic conservatism, into conviviality, and into silence.

Temple University

NOTES TO THE INTRODUCTION

[1] For a survey of all Lloyd's work see Cecil J. L. Price, *A Man of Genius and a Welch Man* (University of Swansea, Wales, 1963). Lloyd is the subject of an unpublished dissertation, *The Moral Beau*, by Paul E. Parnell (New York University, 1956). Two short passages from *The Methodist* are included in *The Penguin Book of Satirical Verse*, ed. Edward Lucie-Smith (Baltimore, 1967).

[2] Most recently, Albert M. Lyles, *Methodism Mocked* (London, 1960).

[3] Journal, 8 February 1753, quoted by A. R. Humphreys, *The Augustan World* (New York, 1963), p. 20.

[4] The pseudonymous author, Peter Paragraph, is identified by Halkett and Laing, *Dictionary of Anonymous and Pseudonymous English Literature*, as James Makittrick Adair. Adair did write some works under that pseudonym but probably did not write *The Methodist and Mimic*. Lyles, *op. cit.*, p. 129n., suggests that the author may be Samuel Foote, in whose play, *The Orators*, a character, Peter Paragraph, appears, probably representing George Faulkner. Robert Lloyd, in "The Cobbler of Cripplegate's Letter," hints that Peter Paragraph may be Bonnel Thornton.

[5] *The Critical Review*, XXIII (1766), pp. 75-77.

[6] *The Power of Satire* (Princeton, 1960), p. 222 and *passim*.

[7] The *Methodist* was reviewed by *The Monthly Review*, XXV (1766), pp. 319-321, and *Gentleman's Magazine*, XXXVI (1766), p. 335. *Conversation* was reviewed more favorably by *The Monthly Review*, XXXVII (1767), p. 394, and by *The Critical Review* XXIV (1767), pp. 341-343. *The Critical Review* compared him with Swift.

BIBLIOGRAPHICAL NOTE

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THE

M E T H O D
I S T .

A

P O E M .

BY

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read "E. Lloyd". The signature is written in a cursive style with a long, sweeping underline that extends to the right.

AUTHOR OF

The Powers of the Pen, and The Curate.

L O N D O N :
P R I N T E D F O R T H E A U T H O R ;
And Sold by RICHARDSON and URQUHART, under the
ROYAL-EXCHANGE, CORNHILL.

MDCCLXVI.

T H E

M E T H O D
I S T .

Nothing, search all creation round,
Nothing so *firmly good* is found,
Whose substance, with such
closeness knit,
Corruption's Touch will not admit;
But, spite of all incroaching stains,
Its native purity retains:
Whose texture will nor warp, nor
fade,
Though moths and weather shou'd
invade,
Which *Time's* sharp tooth cannot
corrode,
Proof against *Accident* and *Mode*;
And, maugre each assailing dart,
Thrown by the hand of Force, or Art,
Remains (let Fate do what it will)
Simple and *uncorrupted* still.

Virtue, of constitution nice,
Quickly degen'rates into *Vice*;
Change but the *Person, Place, and*
Time,
And what was *Merit* turns to *Crime*.
Wisdom, which men with so much
pain,
With so much weariness attain,
May in a little moment quit,
And abdicate the throne of Wit,
And leave, a vacant seat, the brain,
For Folly to usurp and reign.
Should you but discompose the tide,
On which *Ideas* wont to ride,
Ferment it with a *yeasty Storm*,
Or with high *Floods of Wine* deform;
Altho' Sir Oracle is he,
Who is as wise, as wise can be,
In one short minute we shall find
The wise man gone, a fool behind.

Courage, that is all nerve and heart,
That dares confront Death's
brandish'd dart,
That dares to single Fight defy
The stoutest Hector of the sky,
Whose mettle ne'er was known to
slack,
Nor wou'd on thunder turn his back;
How small a matter may controul,
And sooth the fury of his soul!
Shou'd this intrepid Mars, his clay
Dilute with nerve-relaxing Tea,
Thin broths, thin whey, or water-
gruel,
He is no longer fierce and cruel,
But mild and gentle as a dove,
The *Hero's* melted down to *Love*.
The *juices* soften'd, (here we note
More on the *juices* than the *Coat*
Depends, to make a valiant Mars

Rich in the heraldry of scars)
The *Man* is *soften'd* too, and shews
No fondness for a bloody nose.
When *Georgy S—k——le shunn'd the*
Fray,
He'd swill'd a little too much Tea.
Chastity melts like sun-kiss'd snow,
When Lust's hot wind begins to
blow.
Let but that *horrid Creature, Man*,
Breathe on a lady thro' her fan,
Her *Virtue* thaws, and by and bye
Will of the *falling Sickness* die.
Lo! *Beauty*, still more transitory,
Fades in the mid-day of its glory!
For *Nature* in her kindness swore,
That she who kills, shall kill no
more;
And in pure mercy does erase
Each killing feature in the face;

Plucks from the cheek the damask
rose,

E'en at the moment that it blows;
Dims the bright lustre of those eyes
To which the Gods wou'd sacrifice;
Dries the moist lip, and pales its hue,
And brushes off its honied dew;
Flattens the proudly swelling chest,
Furrows the round elastic breast,
And all the Loves that on it play'd,
Are in a tomb of wrinkles laid;
Recalls those charms, which she
design'd

To *please*, and not *bewitch* Mankind;
But with too delicate a touch,
Heightening the *Ornaments* too
much,

She finds her daughters can convert
Blessings to curses, good to hurt,
Proof of parental love to give,

She blots them out that Man may
live.

The hour will come (which let not me
Indulgent Nature, live to see!)

The hour will come, when *Chloe's*
form

Shall with its beauty feed the worm;
That face where troops of Cupids
throng,

Whose charms first warm'd me into
song,

Shall wrinkle, wither, and decay,
To Age, and to Disease, a prey!

Chloe, in whom are so combin'd

The charms of body and of mind,

As might to Earth elicit *Jove*,

Thinking his Heav'n well left for
Love;

Perfection as she is, the hour

Will come, when she must feel the
pow'r

Of *Time*, and to his wither'd arms,

Resign the rifling of her charms!

Must veil her beauties in a cloud,

A grave her bed, her robe a shroud!

When all her glowing, vivid bloom,

Must fade and wither in the tomb!

When she who bears the ensigns
now,

Of Beauty's Priestess on her brow,

Shall to th' abhorr'd embrace of
Death

Give up the sweetness of her breath!

When worms—but stop, *Description*,
there—

My heart cannot the picture bear—

Sickens to think there is a day,

When *Chloe* will be made a prey

To Death, a piece-meal feast for him

With rav'nous jaw to tear each limb,
And feature after feature eat,
While *Beauty* only serves for *Meat*—
Wretched to know that this is true,
Forbear t' anticipate the view!
Hence, *Observation*!—take your
leave!—

And kindly, *Memory*, deceive!
And when some forty years are fled,
And age has on her beauties fed,
Dear *Self-Delusion*! lend thy skill
To fancy she is *Chloe* still!

Cities and *Empires* will decay,
And to *Corruption* fall a prey!
Athens, of arts the native land,
Cou'd not the stroke of Time
withstand;
There Serpents hiss, and ravens

croak,

Where *Socrates* and *Plato* spoke.

Proud *Troy* herself (as all things
must)

Is crumbled into native dust;

Is now a pasture, where the beast

Strays for his vegetable feast,

Old *Priam*'s royal palace now

May couch the ox, the ass, the cow.

—

Rome, city of imperial worth,

The mighty mistress of the earth;

Rome, that gave law to all the world,

Is now to blank Destruction hurl'd!—

Is now a sepulchre, a tomb,

To tell the stranger, “Here was

Rome.”—

View the *West Abbey*! there we see
How frail a thing is royalty!
Where crowns and sceptres worms
supply,
And kings and queens, like lumber
lie.

The *Tombs themselves* are worn
away,

And own the empire of *Decay*,
Mouldering like the royal dust,
Which to preserve they have in trust.
Nor has the *Marble* more withstood
The rage of *Time*, than *Flesh and*
Blood!

The *King of Stone* is worn away,
As well as is the *King of Clay*—
Here lies a *King without a Nose*,
And there a *Prince without his Toes*;
Here on her back a *Royal Fair*
Lies, but a little worse for wear;

Those lips, whose touch cou'd almost
turn

Old age to youth, and make it burn;
To which young kings were proud to
kneel,

Are kick'd by every Schoolboy's
heel;

Struck rudely by the *Showman's*
Wand,

And crush'd by every callous Hand:

Here a *puissant Monarch* frowns

In menace high to rival Crowns;

He threatens—but will do no harm—

Our *Monarch* has not left an arm.

Thus all *Things* feel the gen'ral curse,
That all Things must with Time grow
worse.

But your Philosophers will say,

Best Things grow worst when they

decay.

And many facts they have at hand
To prove it, shou'd you proofs
demand.

As if *Corruption* shut her jaw,
And scorn'd to cram her filthy maw,
With aught but dainties rich and rare,
And morsels of the choicest fare;
As garden Birds are led to bite,
Where'er the fairest fruits invite.
If *Phæbus'* rays too fiercely burn,
The *richest Wines* to *sourest* turn:
And they who living *highly fed*,
Will breed a *Pestilence when dead*.
Thus *Aldermen*, who at each Feast,
Cram Tons of Spices from the East,
Whose leading wish, and only plan,
Is to learn how to *pickle Man*;
Who more than vie with *Ægypt's* art,
And make themselves a *human Tart*,

A walking Pastry-Shop, a Gut,
Shambles by Wholesale to inglut;
And gorge each high-concocted Mess
The art of Cookery can dress:
Yet spite of all, when *Death* thinks fit
To take them off, lest t' other bit
Shou'd burst these *living Mummies*,
able
Neither to eat, nor quit the Table;
Whether He Dropsy sends or Gout,
To fetch them by the Shoulders out;
Tho' living they were *Salt and Spice*,
The carcase is not over nice;
And all may find, who have a *Nose*,
Dead Aldermen are not a rose.

This reas'ning only serves to shew,
The world call'd *Natural*, is so.
But various instances proclaim,
'Tis in the *moral World* the same.

Thus *Woman*, Nature's *chastest* work,
Lust-struck, out-paramours the Turk;
Tho' *gentle* as the suckling Child,
Enrag'd, than famish'd Wolves more
wild;

A more fell minister of *Death*—
Rime gives the instance in *Mackbeth*.

Reason herself, that *sober Dame*,
So mild, so temperate, so tame,
Her head once turn'd, and giddy
grown,

Raving with phrenzy not her own,
Plays madder pranks, more full of
spleen

Than any Hoyden of sixteen.

Whether she burns with *Love* or
Hate,

Or grows with *baseless Hopes* elate,
With *Desperation* is forlorn,

Or with imagin'd horrors torn,
If on *Ambition's* swelling tide,
Her crazy bark from side to side,
Reels like a drunkard, tempest-tost,
Or in the *Gulph of Pride* is lost;
Whate'er the *leading Passion* be,
That works the Soul's anxiety,
In each *Extreme* th' effect is bad,
Sense grows diseas'd, and *Reason*
mad.

Why shou'd the Muse of *Angels* tell
Turn'd into *Devils* when they fell?
Why search the Chronicles of *Hell*,
While *Earth* examples it as well?
Why talk of *Satan*, while we see
Each day some new Apostacy?
Tories to *Whigs* convert, and *Whigs*,
Mere Ministerial Whirlegigs,
Turn'd by the hand of *Int'rest*, take

The *Tory-part*, for Lucre's sake.

Patriots turn *Placemen*, and support
Against their Country's good the
Court;

Are bought with *Pensions* to retire,
When drooping Kingdoms most
require

Their aid——Tho' here the Muse
wou'd fain

Except ONE of the *pension'd Train*,
(*One* meritorious 'bove the rest,
A patriot Minister, confest)

Yet strictest honour can't acquit
That *Pensioner*, who once was *P*
——.

Instance on instance to my view
Come rushing, of the changeling
crew,

That I could quarrel with my Nature,
To think that Man is such a Creature

—
And are we all a fickle tribe,
Venal to ev'ry golden bribe?
Is there not one of honour found,
In all the List of *Placemen* found?
Yes—one there is, in perils tried,
Yet never known to *change his Side*,
Or *Principles*—nor think it strange,
He ne'er had *Principles* to change,
And for a *Side* (the proof is new)
He's *none*, because that *he has two*.
Throw him from *Party's* giddy
heights,
A *Cat in Politics* he lights
Ever upon his feet; his heart
Clings both to *Whig* and *Tory-part*;
Is *this*, is *that*, is *both*, or *neither*,
And still keeps shifting with the
Weather.
Who does not know that *T—s—d's*

he,

That reads the *Book of Ministry*?

Thus let us turn where'er we will,
Each Machiavel's a Changeling still.

But tho' among all *Nature's* works
The seed of foul *Corruption* lurks,
Yet no where is it known to bear
So vile a Crop on Ground so fair,
As when upon *Religion's* root
It raises Diabolic Fruit.

When the Almighty Father's Love
Call'd Things to Being, from above
Millions of winged *Blessings* flew,
Sent from his right hand, to bedew
The new-born Earth, and from their
wings

Shed good on all *created Things*.
Precious and various tho' the store
Which down to Earth these Legates

bore,
That *Heav'nly Spark* we *Reason* call,
Was far the richest boon of all.

By *this* we find *th' Almighty Cause*
From whom the World its Being
draws;

By whom *Earth's* plenteous Table's
spread,

At which each living Creature's fed;
Who gave the *Breath of Life*, and
whence

This fine *Variety of Sense*;
Whose Hands unfold the azure sky,
Sublimely pleasing to *the Eye*;
Who tun'd the feather'd Songster's
throat,

Giving such softness to his note,
To fill the *Ear* with dulcet sound,
And pour sweet Music all around;

Who on the teeming Branches plac'd
Such various Fruit to please the
Taste;

What bounteous Hand perfum'd the
Rose,

And ev'ry scented Flow'r that blows,
And wafts its fragrance thro' the
Vale,

Courting the *Smell* in ev'ry gale,
To *whom* it is we owe so much
Substantial pleasure in the *Touch*;
And *whence*, superior to the whole,
Those raptures that transport *the*
Soul;

This gives our Gratitude to glow
To him, from whom such Blessings
flow;

This teaches Man his *moral Part*,
And grafts *Religion* in the Heart.

Glory to God, good Will to Man,
And Peace on Earth, compos'd the
plan,
For which *Religion* first came down,
And brought to Earth a *heav'nly*
Crown.

Better her Purpose to complete,
And *Satan's* Malice to defeat,
A Troop of *holy Genii* came,
Co-workers in the glorious Scheme.
To each a scroll the Goddess gave,
On which these lines She did
engrave:

“Go, teach the sons of Men to raise
Their voice unto their *Maker's* praise.
Go, call forth *Charity* to meet
Distress that seeks her in the Street;
Bid her the lame with Legs supply,
And be unto the blind an Eye;
A Mantle o'er the naked throw,

And reach a healing hand to Woe;
Visit the bed where Sickness lies,
And wipe the tears from Orphans
eyes;
Bid her Affliction's hour beguile,
And teach the tear-worn Cheek to
smile;
Bid her send Comfort to expell
Grief from the lonely Widow's Cell;
Make blunt the arrows of Mischance,
And ope the eyes of Ignorance;
To those lost Pilgrims point the Way,
Who in *Sin's* tenfold Darkness stray,
Recall them from *Hell's* thickest
night,
And shew *Salvation's* glorious Light;
For thus the World that Peace shall
find,
For which it was by *God*
design'd."—

Such the commands *Religion* gave,
When first she came the World to
save,

Such the attendants in her Train,
When She began her holy Reign.

And when *Messiah's* gracious Love
Urg'd him to leave the *Realms* above,
Urg'd him to quit his *heav'nly*
Throne,

His People's Trespass to atone,
And, tho' so long they had withstood
His Will, to wash them with his
Blood;

The great Command he did renew,
To *give to God, and Man his due*;
Bade the bright *Sun of Faith* arise,
And open'd Heav'n to mortal eyes,
Leaving *Religion* on the Earth,
More fair and pure than at her Birth.

How mutilated now and marr'd,
Deform'd, distorted, mangled,
scarr'd!

Thro' *modern Conventicles* trace
The Goddess, you'll not know her
face:

The *holy Genii* all are fled,
And *Sprites* and *Dev'ls* come in their
stead.

And now a counterfeiting Dame
Usurps *Religion's* sacred Name,
But no more like in *Heart* or *Face*,
Than *F—x's* deeds to deeds of Grace.

Visit her at her *T-tt—m* Seat,
You'll find she is an errant Cheat.

For *Satan*, Man's invet'rate foe,
Whose greatest joy is human woe,
Repining at the heav'nly Plan,
That promis'd so much Good to Man,
Us'd all his Malice, Wit, and Pow'r,

The World's great Blessings to
devour.

Well the *malicious Spirit* knew
Whence *Man* his chief resources
drew

Of Happiness, and saw confest,
Where all was good, *Religion* best;
And at her unpolluted Heart
He aim'd his most envenom'd Dart.

He knew the Interest of *Hell*
Cou'd never on the *Earth* go well,
While *pure Religion* did maintain
O'er *Man* a sanctimonious reign.
With her he wag'd malicious War,
He might, if not destroy her, mar
Her Face; might with false Lights
misguide,

And make her Combat on his side.
Highly did his *Ambition* burn
Heav'n's Arms against itself to turn.

Nor would his *Malice* triumph less,
To *damn* where *God* design'd to
bless.

For this *the Fiend* to Earth ascends,
To try his Int'rest with his Friends.
Long in his fiery Chariot hurl'd,
He had explor'd the pendent World;
Long had he search'd without avail,
Each *Meeting, Dungeon, Court, and*
Jail,

Each *Mart of Villainy*, where *Vice*
Presides, and *Virtue* bears no Price,
Where *Fraud, Hypocrisy, and Lies*
Are selling while the Devil buys.
Long had he search'd, but could not
find

An *Agent* suited to his Mind,
Who cou'd transact his Business
well,

And do on Earth the work of Hell;
That he might at his leisure go,
And manage his Affairs below.—

Tir'd and despairing of a Friend
On whom he safely might depend,
At *T-tt—m* he alights from Air—
Magus, that *Sorcerer*, was there.
Pleas'd *Satan* somewhat nearer drew,
Look'd thro' him at a single view,
Bless'd his good Luck, and grinn'd
aghast—

“’Tis well, for I have found at last,
The Thing I long have sought, in
Thee,

An Agent in Iniquity.

Thus let me mark Thee for my own,
And from henceforth for *mine* be
known.”

Then with out-stretched claws his
Eyes

He *twisted* diff'rent ways—the *Skies*
Are watch'd by *one*, and (strange to
tell!)

The *other* is the Guard of *Hell*.

Then thus—“’Tis fit thy Eyes shou’d
roll,

Cross as the purpose of thy Soul,
Fit that they look a diff'rent way,
Like what You *do*, and what You say;
Thy *Eye-balls* now are pois’d and
hung,

As even as thy *Heart* and *Tongue*—
Prosper—to *me*, to *Hell* (he cried)
Be true, but false to all beside.

Riches are mine—I will repay
For ev’ry Soul you lead astray—
Give out thyself a Light to shew
Which way ’tis best to Heav’n to go;

But lead the Pilgrims wrong, and
shine

An *Ignis fatuus* of mine—

Draw them thro' bog, thro' brake,
thro' mire,

I'll dry them at a *rousing Fire*."

Magus complacent smil'd—his Eyes
Twinkled with signs of Joy, one flies
Upward, and t'other down, like
Scales,

Where this ascends, when that
prevails—

Then *thrice* he turn'd upon his heel,
And swore Allegiance to the *De'el*—

Right faithfully his *Oath* he kept,
And might each Night before he slept
Boast of his labours to maintain,
And spread abroad his *Master's*
Reign;

Might boast the magic of his Rod
To whip away the *Love of God*,
For all of *God* he makes appear
Has nought to *love*, but all to *fear*.
That debt, which *Gratitude* each day
Paying, wou'd still own much to pay;
Instead of *Duty* freely paid,
A Tyrant's hard Exaction's made.
Fitted the simple to cajole,
First of his Wits, and then his Soul,
He urges fifty false Pretences,
Preaching his Hearers from their
Senses.
He knows his *Master's* Realm so
well,
His Sermons are a *Map of Hell*,
An *Ollio* made of *Conflagration*,
Of *Gulphs of Brimstone*, and
Damnation,
Eternal Torments, Furnace, Worm,

Hell-Fire, a *Whirlwind*, and a *Storm*,
With *Mammon*, *Satan*, and *Perdition*,
And *Beelzebub* to help the Dish on;
Belial and *Lucifer*, and all
The *nick-Names* which *old Nick* we
call—

But he has ta'en especial care,
To have nor *Sense* nor *Reason* there.
A thousand scorching Words beside,
Over his tongue as glibly slide,
Familiar as a glass of wine,
Or a Tobacco-pipe on mine;
That You wou'd swear he was
compleater,
Than *Powell*, as a *Fire-Eater*.

Virgins he will seduce astray,
Only to shew the shortest Way
To *Heaven*, and because it lies
Above the *Zodiac* in the Skies,

That they *may better see the Track*,
He lays them down *upon their Back*.
Domestic Peace he can destroy,
And the confusion view with Joy,
Children from Parents he can draw,
What's *Conscience*?—he is safe from
Law—

The closest Union can divide,
Take Husbands from their Spouses'
side,

But it turns out to better Use,
Wives from their Husbands to
seduce;

And as their Journey lies *up-Hill*,
Ev'ry Incumbrance were an Ill;
And lest their Speed shou'd be
withstood,

He takes their *Money*—*for their*
Good.

Such is the Agent *Satan* chose,
Religion's Progress to oppose—
Too great the Task for *one* was
thought,
And *under-Agents* must be sought—
On this high Enterprize intent,
A troop of *evil Sprites* he sent,
Commission'd, wheresoe'er they
found
Hearts hollow, rotten, and unsound,
Within those Breasts accurs'd to
dwell,
Teaching the Liturgy of *Hell*.
Big with the Charge th' infernal Crew
To their belov'd Appointment flew;
With busy search thro' ev'ry Class,
Thro' ev'ry Rank of Men they pass,
In ev'ry Class of Men they find
Some *Hearts* corrupted to their Mind,
Ev'ry Profession they explore,

Ev'ry Profession gives them more;
The higher Functions ransack'd, now
Each vulgar Trade, each sweaty
Brow

Is search'd, and in them all were
found,

Some hollow, rotten, and unsound.

In each depraved Bosom dwell
These *Sprites*, nor miss their native
Hell.

Hence ev'ry Blockhead, Knave, and
Dunce,

Start into Preachers all at once.

Hence Ignorance of ev'ry size,

Of ev'ry shape Wit can devise,

Altho' so dull it hardly knows,

Which are its Fingers, which its Toes,

Which is the left Hand, which the
Right,

When it is Day, or when 'tis Night,

Shall yet pretend to keep the Key
Of *God's* dark Secrets, and display
His *hidden Mysteries*, as free
As if *God's privy Council* He,
Shall to his Presence rush, and dare
To raise a *pious Riot* there.

Lawyers (a Commutation strange!)
Coke Littleton for *Bible* change;
Quit their beloved wrangling *Hall*,
More loudly in a *Church* to bawl:
Statutes at large are thrown aside,
And now the *Testament's* their guide;
And full as fervent, on their Knees,
For *Heav'n* they pray, as once for
Fees;
Plaintiff, Defendant, and my Lord,
Are banish'd, and now *Faith's* the
Word,
Of *Briefs* no longer now they dream,

Religion is the only Theme.

The *Physic-Tribe* their Art resign,

And lose the *Quack* in the *Divine*;

Galen lies on the Shelf unread,

A *Pray'r-Book* open in its stead;

Salvation now is all the *Cant*,

Salvation is the *only* Want.

“*Throw Physic to the Dogs*,” they
cry,

’Twill never bring you to the Sky.

Of a *New-birth* they prate, and prate

While *Midwifry* is out of Date;

Let Fevers, Agues, take their turn,

To freeze the Patient, or to burn,

In vain he seeks the *Physic Tribe*,

No *Recipe* will they prescribe,

But what is sovereign to controul

The *Maladies* that hurt the Soul.

And tho’ while *Body-quacks*, with
Pill

Or *Bolus*, 'twas their Trade to kill,
More miserably still, alack!
For the *diseased Soul* they *quack*.

The *Sons of War* sometimes are
known
To fight with Weapons not their own,
Ceasing the *Sword of Steel* to wield,
They take *Religion's Sword and
Shield*.

Ev'ry *Mechanic* will commence
Orator, without *Mood* or *Tense*.
Pudding is *Pudding* still, they know,
Whether it has a Plumb or no;
So, tho' the Preacher has no skill,
A *Sermon* is a *Sermon* still.

The *Bricklay'r* throws his *Trowel* by,
And now *builds Mansions in the Sky*;
The *Cobbler*, touch'd with *holy*

Pride,
Flings his *old Shoes*, and *Last* aside,
And now devoutly sets about
Cobbling of *Souls* that *ne'er wear*
out;

The *Baker*, now a *Preacher* grown,
Finds Man *lives not by Bread alone*,
And now his Customers he feeds
With *Pray'rs*, with *Sermons*, *Groans*
and *Creeds*;

The *Tinman*, mov'd by Warmth
within,

Hammers the *Gospel*, just like *Tin*;
Weavers inspir'd their *Shuttles* leave,
Sermons, and *flimsy Hymns* to
weave;

Barbers unreap'd will leave the *Chin*,
To trim, and shave the *Man within*;
The *Waterman* forgets his *Wherry*,
And opens a *celestial Ferry*;

The *Brewer*, bit by Phrenzy's Grub,
The *Mashing* for the *Preaching Tub*
Resigns, *those Waters* to explore,
Which if You drink, you *thirst no*
more;

The *Gard'ner*, weary of his Trade,
Tir'd of the Mattock, and the Spade,
Chang'd to *Apollos* in a Trice,
Waters the Plants of Paradise;
The *Fishermen* no longer set
For *Fish* the Meshes of their Net,
But catch, like *Peter*, *Men of Sin*,
For *catching* is to *take them in*.

Well had the wand'ring Spirits sped,
And thro' the World their Poison
spread,
Made Lodgments in each tainted
Breast;
And each infected Heart possess'd.

The *wayward Bus'ness* being done,
Satan to make his Choice begun
Of *under-Ministers*, to do
What *One* cou'd not be equal to.

A *second Agent*, like the first,
Who on *Dæmoniac Milk* was nurst,
Had *Moorfields* trusted to his Care,
For *Satan* keeps an *Office* there.
Lean is the *Saint*, and *lank*, to shew
That *Flesh and Blood to Heav'n* can't
go;
His Hair like *Candles* hangs, a sign
How bright his *inward Candles*
shine.

Of *Satan's Agents* these *the Chief*,
A thousand others lend Relief,
And take some labour off their
Hands,
Each as th' *internal Sprite*

commands:

But working with a *diff'rent Spell*,
They lead by various Ways to *Hell*.

Sickens the Soul? and is its state
With *Sin's* Disease grown desperate?
To divers Quacks you may apply,
And *special Nostrums* of them buy.
Tottenham's the best accustom'd
Place,
There *Magus squints* Men into
Grace.

W-s—y sells Powders, Draughts, and
Pills,

Sov'reign against all sorts of Ills,
Assurance charms away the Fit,

Or at least makes it intermit—

M-d—n the springs of Health
unlocks,

And by his Preaching cures the *P—*

R-m—ne works greater Wonders still,
Pulls you by *Gravity up-Hill*,
And for whate'er you do *amiss*,
Rewards you with *celestial Bliss*;
By your *bad Deeds* your *Faith* you
shew,

'Tis but *believe*, and *up You go*.

B—rr—s and *W-r—r* set up Shop,
To sell *Religion's Pill and Drop*,
They teach their Patients how to fly
On *Voice* and *Action* to the Sky.

One of the *Magi of the East*,
A little perking, puppet-Priest,
Has got the *Harlequino-way*,
His Patients Heav'nward to convey;
And their Salvation to advance,
A Jig will at the Altar dance.

Such were the *Plenipo's* in *Town*,
Who serv'd the *Diabolic Crown*.

Not far remov'd, a *female Friend*
Gave Proofs, that *Satan* might
depend

On her best Service, and support,
For what serv'd him, to her was
Sport.

H——, cloy'd with *carnal* Bliss,
Longing to taste how *Spirits* kiss,
Bids *Chapels* for her *Saints* arise,
Which are but *Bagnios* in Disguise;
Where She may suck her *T*——'s
Breath,
Expiring in *seraphic* Death.

That *Satan* better might succeed,
Of *other Agents* he had need,
His *Country-Int'rest* to support,
While *Dodd* was *preaching* to the
Court.

The Town was left, and now his

Flight

Bore to the *North* the horrid *Sprite*;
Now had he travers'd many a
League,

And felt, as *Spirits* feel, Fatigue,
When, in a dark, romantic Wood,
In which an antique Mansion stood,
He spied, close to a Hovel-door,
A *Saint* conversing with his *Whore*.
Double he seem'd, and worn with
Age,

Little adapted to engage
In *Love's* hot War, too dry his Trunk
To cope with a lascivious Punk;
So humble too he seem'd, You'd
swear,

Humility herself was there;
So like a *Sawyer* too he bows,
You'd think that he was *Meekness'*
Spouse;

But *Satan* read his *Visage-lines*,
And found some favourable Signs,
That this *meek Saint* might, in the
Dark,

Make his *Infernalship* a *Clerk*;
Tho' muffled in *Religion's* Cloak
So close, that it might almost choak
A *Pharisee*, it might be still
Only a *Cloak* to doff at Will;
His *Speech* might be an acted Part,
A Language foreign to his *Heart*.
He knew, that tho' upon his *Tongue*,
Religion, a mere *Cant-word*, hung,
He might forget it in his *Work*,
And be at *Heart* a very *Turk*.

Finesse and *Trick* wou'd ne'er
succeed,

If Men wou'd only learn to read,
To read the Lines of *Nature's* Pen,

Drawn in the *Countenance of Men*,
Where Truth speaks out distinct and
clear,
If we had but the Trick to hear.

So far'd it with *our Saint*, while He
Wou'd seem downright *Humility*,
Some honest Features cry'd aloud,
“Our Master is of Spirit proud.”
Pass him with Bonnet on, his Lip
Will hang as low as to his Hip;
His bloated Eye its Venom darts,
And from its gloomy Socket starts;
And if the *Body's* frame we scan,
He cannot be an *upright Man*.
And there are Proofs, from which we
see
His *Body* and his *Soul* agree.
Altho' he is as fond of *Pray'rs*,
As Country Girls of Country Fairs;

Yet shou'd he in the Church-yard spy
Some *tempting Wanton* passing by,
E'en at the Moment that his Knee
Is bent in Sign of *Piety*,
Quick his *Devotion* leaves the *Heart*,
And settles in some *other Part*;
The Book of *Pray'r* is shut, and
Heav'n
For the dear Charms of *Cælia* giv'n.

Th' *Arch-Fiend* this *saintly Sinner*
spied,
And with malicious Pleasure ey'd,
Well pleas'd to think that he had
found
Such a *Hell-Factor* above Ground;
And thus began th' infernal Sprite—
“*Libidinoso!* if I'm right!
Art thou that Son of mine on Earth,
Whose deeds so loud proclaim thy

Birth?

Of whom so many Strumpets tell
Such Tales as get Thee Fame in *Hell*?
But Children know not whence they
spring,

Whether by Beggar got, or King;
Yet I by *certain Marks* can know,
Whether Thou art *my Child*, or no.
Uncase—and let me see your Waist

—

For there are private Tokens plac'd,
By which *my own* I know—if there
No secret Lines of mine appear,
I claim Thee not—but if I see
The two *Initials F and P*,
Then art Thou *mine*—nay, never start

—

And *Heav'n* can claim *in Thee* no
Part"—

And now his sapless Trunk he
stripp'd,

Like Culprits sentenc'd to be
whipp'd,

When lo! th' *Initials* rose to View,
And prov'd the Fiend's Conjecture
true.

And all his Waist (detested Brand!)
Was scribbled with the *Dev'l's short*
Hand;

Was mark'd with *Whoredom, Lust,*
and *Letchery,*

Malice, Hypocrisy, and Treachery,

With *Envy, Lying, and Betraying,*

With *Fasting, Wenching, Fiddling,*
Praying,

And all the *Catalogue of Sin*

Deeply engraven in his Skin—

Pleas'd the *grim Pow'r* survey'd, and
smil'd,

Embrac'd and said—"My darling
Child,
Blest was the Hour, and blest the
Spot,
Where Thou, *my 'Bidin*, wert begot.
Know then, you're not what You
profess,
Her Son, whose Lands you do
possess;
No—Thou'rt *my wayward Son*, a
Witch
Litter'd thee in a loathsome Ditch;
And (for all Creatures love the Young
Which from their proper Loins are
sprung)
To this old Mansion thee convey'd,
And in an Infant's Cradle laid:
And when the *Sorc'ress* plac'd thee
there,
She stole away the *native Heir*—

Right well hast Thou, my Boy, repaid
The *Obligations* on thee laid,
And to thy Parents' Int'rest true
Hast prov'd thy Fortunes were thy
due—

Go on—and, if thou canst, do more
(But 't may not be) than heretofore—
Keep the same Path You always trod,
And be an Enemy to *God*;
Apply your Fortune to oppress,
And harrass *Virtue* with Distress;
To hide your Blemishes use Paint,
To screen the *Villain* play the *Saint*;
Affect *Religion*, *Church* frequent,
Kneel, *seem* to pray, and keep up
Lent—

Charity too must be display'd,
But *Charity in Masquerade*;
Give *Alms*—but not to those that
need,

But only for the *Gallows feed*;
Whene'er you meet a *preaching Thief*,
Be prompt to reach him out Relief;
If *Liars, Flatt'ers, Pandars, Pimps*,
Or any of my vagrant Imps,
Approach Thee, to thy Mansion take,
And give them Welcome for my Sake;
But *needy Merit* must not dare
To hope with these *thy Alms* to share,
Commit *that* to the *Bridewell-lash*,
But give it neither *Food* nor *Cash*;
Distinguish'd Honour shalt thou gain
In *Pandæmonium*, for thy Pain.
But—one Word more—My Mind
misgives,
That *Virtue* a near *Neighbour* lives—
For in my search to find out Thee,
I spied in this Vicinity

A Knot of Friends, where I cou'd
trace

Honour emblazon'd in their Face,
These (for their Thoughts I plainly
see)

Bear no good Will to you or me;
Foolishly honest, cheap they hold
Libidinoso and his Gold,
And will maintain, to Conscience
true,

Their Virtue, spite of Me and You.

Altho' your Influence be weak,
Oppose them for *opposing*' Sake,
Do ev'ry little Act of Spite,

And snarl, altho' You cannot bite—
Be faithful—there will come a Day,

When I thy Services will pay,
Will bring Thee to my Realm, and
make

Thee *Pilot of the burning Lake.*”

He said—and quick as Thought
withdrew,

And to th' infernal Regions flew;
Blue sulph'rous streaks the Peasants
scare,

Marking his passage thro' the Air—

Libidinoso left behind,

Began revolving in his Mind

His Master's Promises, and sigh'd

To have them fully ratified;

Then homeward plodded, (but, be
sure,

Before he went, he kiss'd his Whore)

Resolv'd, if possible, on more

And greater Evils than before.

All vain was the Resolve—his Cup

Of *Wickedness* was quite fill'd up,

And no Cup can another drop

Contain, when fill'd up to the Top.

Since all Improvement was forbid,
What cou'd he do, but what he did?
Nought he diminish'd of the Charge,
But acts *Hell's* Minister at large.

A Pair of Adamantine Lungs,
A Throat of Brass, Fame's hundred
Tongues,
Time out of Mind have been confest,
By *fifty Poets*, at the least,
Too little to count *Hybla's Bees*,
The *Leaves that cloathe the Forest-*
Trees;
The *Sands that broider Neptune's*
Side,
Or *Waves* that on his Bosom ride;
The *Grains* which rich *Sicilia* yields,
The *Blades* with which *Spring* robes
the Fields;
The *Stars* which twinkling on the

sight

Jove's Threshold make so glorious
bright:

Or (if we may annex to these
Modern Impossibilities)

To reckon up the sum of *Knaves*
That crawl on *Earth*, or sleep in
Graves,

To count the *Prudes* that crowd to
Pews,

While their *Thoughts* ramble to the
Stews,

Lords, whose sole Merit is their
Place,

Ladies, whose Worth's a *painted*
Face,

Who find *my Lord* has lost his *Force*
In *Love*, and sue for a *Divorce*;

Or to abridge, and enter down
The Names of all the *Fools in Town*;

Or number those who *live by Ink*,
And *write*, altho' they cannot *think*;
Critics, who judge, but cannot read,
And *praise*, or *censure*—as they're
fee'd;

Or count *each Bard* by *Self* betray'd,
Who thought, when fondled by *his*
Maid,

It was *Melpomene* that smil'd,
And mark'd him for her fav'rite
Child,

But finds the *Harvest* of his Lines,
Is to *fast twice* for *once he dines*.

As well the *Muse* might one of these
Poets' Impossibilities

Assay to do, and speed as well,
As if She should attempt to tell
The *Names* and *Characters* of *all*
That on the Name of *Satan* call,

That preach, and lie, and whine, and
cant,

Soldiers for *Hell's Church Militant*;
And use the Head, the Heart, the
Hand,

To spread *its Doctrines* thro' the
Land.

Arithmetic herself were dumb,
If task'd with such an endless Sum;
Nor wou'd the *Muse*, tho' one more
Line

Wou'd all the Host of *Hell* entwine,
Bestow another drop of Ink,
To map out an *infernal Sink*—

Thou God of Truth and Love! excuse
The *honest Anger* of the *Muse*,
Warm in *thy Cause*, while She wou'd
pray

That Thou from *Earth* wou'd'st

sweep away

Such *rotten Saints*, who wou'd
conceal

Their *Fraud* beneath the Name of
Zeal!

Who, mask'd with *spurious Piety*,
Trample on *Reason, Truth, and Thee*,
And, while their hot Career they run,
Tread on the *Gospel* of thy Son!

Who, feigning to adore, make Thee
A *Tyrant-God* of Cruelty!

As if thy *right Hand* did contain
Only an Universe of Pain,
Hell and *Damnation* in thy *Left*,
Of ev'ry gracious Gift bereft,
Hence raining Floods of Grief and
Woes,

On those that never were thy Foes,
Ordaining Torments for the doom
Of Infants, yet within the Womb:

By fifty false Devices more,
Which *Reason* never heard before,
And *Methodists* alone cou'd dream,
Thy boundless *Goodness* they
blaspheme!

Who (tho' our *Saviour's* gracious
Plan

Was to teach Happiness to Man,
By *friendly Arguments* to win
The World from Slavery to Sin;
For He, who all Things knows, well
knew,

That they to Duty are more true,
Who from a *filial Love* obey,
And serve for *Gratitude*, than they
Who from a *coward Dread of Law*
Owe all their *Virtue* to their *Awe*;
Who, tho' they seem so true, and just,
So strictly faithful to their Trust,
Will, if you take the *Gallows* down,

Out-pilfer half the *Rogues* in *Town*).
With saucy boldness will presume
To pass th' impenetrable gloom,
And lift the Curtain which we see
Is drawn betwixt the World and Thee;
Of nought but endless Torments
speak,
To frighten and appall the weak;
Dwell on the horrid Theme with glee,
And fain themselves wou'd
Hangmen be;
With so much *Dread* their *Hearers*
fill,
That they have neither *Pow'r*, nor
Will,
Tho' *Heav'n's* the Prize, to move a
Hand,
But *shuddering* and *trembling* stand.

Quench the hot Flame, O God, that
burns,

And *Piety* to *Phrenzy* turns!

Let not thy *holy Name* be made

A *Cloak* to hide a *pilf'ring Trade*!

Nor suffer that thy *sacred Word*,

Be turn'd to *Rhapsody absurd*!

Let it not serve, like *Magic Sticks*,

To preface *pious Jugglers'* Tricks!

Root, root from *Earth*, these baneful
weeds,

That choak *Religion's wholesome
Seeds*!

Give them the headlong Winds to
bear,

And scatter in a desert Air!

Grind them to Powder, that no more

They sprout and grow as heretofore!

Burn the rank stalks, and let the
flame

Thy Garden's hot luxuriance tame,
Nor let it Flow'r, or Plant produce,
But what yields *Ornament* or *Use*!

But soft—my *Muse*! thy Breath recall

—

Turn not *Religion*'s Milk to Gall!
Let not thy *Zeal* within thee nurse
A holy Rage, or *pious Curse*!
Far other is the *heav'nly Plan*,
Which the *Redeemer* gave to Man,
Who taught the World in Peace to
live,
And e'en *our Enemies* forgive!

Live then, *ye Wretches*! to declare,
How long *our God* with Men *can*
bear!

A living Monument to be
Of the *Almighty*'s Clemency!
Who still is good, altho' You preach

Yourselves almost 'bove *Mercy's*
reach;

And, tho' his goodness You resist,
Can even spare a *Methodist*.

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